

Romanesque

While Byzantine and Islamic architecture were flourishing, areas of western Europe that had once been part of the Roman Empire were in decline. It was not until Charlemagne (c.742–814 CE) was crowned Holy Roman Emperor in 800 that a significant new architectural style spread across Europe.

Charlemagne, determined to unite his empire and validate his reign, began building churches modelled after those of early Christian Rome. The resultant style was a fusion of Roman, Carolingian and Ottonian, Byzantine and Germanic traditions, with a generally massive and heavy quality. Romanesque churches were built on cruciform (cross-shaped) plans, with side aisles, galleries and a large tower over the nave and transept (central crossing point). Stone barrel or groin vaults supported the roofs, walls were thick, arches were usually semicircular and windows were both few and small. As the Romanesque spread across Italy, France, Germany, Scandinavia and England, it diversified into many local styles.



Church of Saint Nectaire, France, c.1150